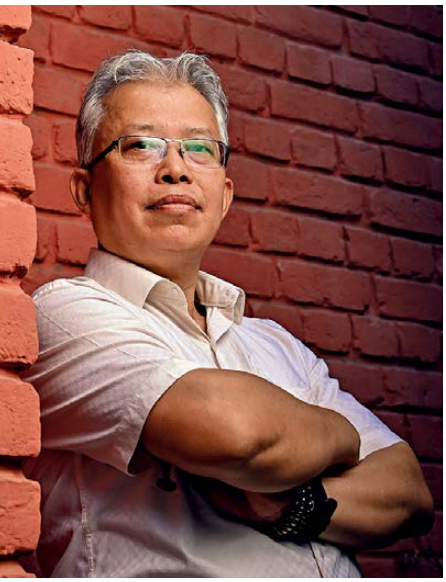


AN ESTEEMED FACULTY

School teachers as well as professors of business, computer science and cultural studies, they got out of classrooms, stepped into the hurly burly of politics and have landed first-time Lok Sabha success



RAJWANT RAWAT

◀ ANGOMCHA BIMOL AKOIJAM, *57*

| CONGRESS | *Inner Manipur, Manipur*

Angomcha Bimol Akoijam, a professor at Jawaharlal Nehru University, wears many hats. The Meitei academic from Manipur is also a filmmaker and, if you ask his mother, had a brighter future as a musician. Indeed, in a viral video, he was seen singing a song by the rock band Scorpions. Known for his expertise in social/political psychology and cultural studies, his was a strong voice from Manipur in the national media during the Meitei-Kuki-Zo ethnic conflict. Critical of the government's role, he accused the Indian Army and Assam Rifles of bias and documented the media's alleged prejudice against Meiteis. His victory over the BJP's Thounaojam B.K. Singh accounting for 47 per cent vote share in the Meitei-dominated seat reflected popular dissatisfaction.

▶ RABINDRA NARAYAN BEHERA, *61*

| BJP | *Jajpur (SC), Odisha*

Rabindra Narayan Behera will have a story to tell all his life. The debutant MP lost to Sarmistha Sethi of the BJD by 496 EVM votes. But when postal ballots were counted, he marched ahead with a lead of less than 2,000 votes. A professor of computer science engineering at the Synergy Engineering College in Dhenkanal, Behera has a PhD in computer science from Utkal University.





▲ RICKY ANDREW J. SYNGKON, *52*

| VOICE OF THE PEOPLE PARTY | *Shillong (ST), Meghalaya*

Ricky Andrew J. Syngkon entered politics in 2023, when he contested, and lost, in the Meghalaya assembly polls. Now, Syngkon, from the Voice of the People Party, has defeated three-time Congress MP Vincent Pala by 370,000 votes in the Shillong LS seat. The assistant professor of small business and entrepreneurship at North-Eastern Hill University has an MA in Economics, an MCom and a PhD. Syngkon is also a church elder at Pohkseh Presbyterian Church, and was supported by the Church during his campaign.



▲ VARSHA GAIKWAD, *49*

| CONGRESS | *Mumbai North Central*

In the 2004 LS polls, little-known Dalit leader and then Dharavi MLA Eknath Gaikwad defeated Lok Sabha speaker Manohar Joshi from the Mumbai North Central seat. His daughter Varsha, an academic and three-term MLA from Dharavi and president of the city Congress, has won the reconstituted seat, beating the special public prosecutor in the 2008 Mumbai terror attack Ujjwal Nikam by over 16,000 votes. Riding on support from ally Shiv Sena (UBT), the former professor of mathematics got her calculations right against the BJP.